

MONGOLIAN WARLORD Born c. 1162 Died 1227

Genghis Khan

“A man of great **ability, eloquence, and valor.**”

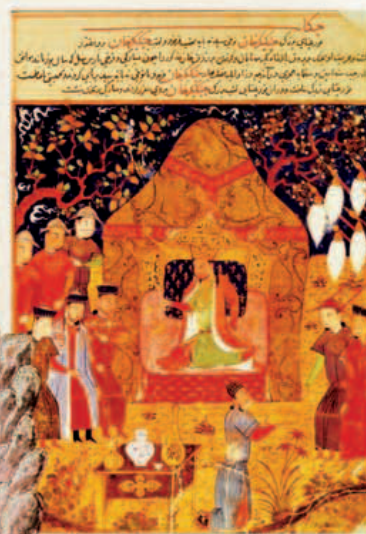
MARCO POLO, *THE TRAVELS OF MARCO POLO*, 1298

Before he became known as Genghis Khan—a title he took in 1206 to proclaim his leadership of the Mongol tribes—the future warlord and conqueror was known simply as Temüjin. Born around 1162 to a minor chieftain in the mountains of eastern Mongolia, there was little in Temüjin’s early life to indicate he would one day be ruler of the world’s largest unbroken empire. When he was just five years old, his father was murdered and his family disinherited by their clan. For much of his childhood, Temüjin was forced to eke out a precarious nomadic existence with his siblings and their indomitable mother, Hoelun.

These early years must have done much to forge the great warrior and leader that Temüjin was to become. As the eldest male, Temüjin was the head of his family and quickly learned to make useful alliances. Having proved himself as a warrior by retrieving some stolen horses, Temüjin claimed a wife, Börte, from a neighboring tribe. He is said to have used her dowry of precious sable furs to win the favor of Toghrul

Engraving

According to a contemporary Persian chronicle, the Mongol emperor was a tall, long-bearded man with red hair and green eyes. This is how a 20th-century French artist depicted him.



Homage to a chief

Genghis Khan receives the homage of his vassals in this 14th-century Persian miniature. The white horse tails flying from his tent signify peace and diplomacy. Black horse tails meant war.

Battle scene

This Chinese painting depicts the Mongol cavalry in action on a mountain pass. Genghis Khan’s highly disciplined army comprised battalions, or *tumens*, of 10,000 warriors, in turn divided into 1,000-man regiments.

